

Step 2 · The spec

Ninety minutes. The scorecard asks one question of this document: could an engineer who has never met you build from it? Twenty points, won in the two sections most PRDs skip.

WHERE THIS GETS YOU · STEP 2 OF 3



When this is done you hold: a PRD a stranger could build the one flow from, 4 to 6 non-goals with reasons, pass-or-fail acceptance criteria with thresholds you chose, an In list and a Not now list, and judgement line 2 of 3. **Banked: Spec, 20 points. Carries into C.4:** the In list becomes layer 2 of the build brief and the non-goals become the fence, which is what makes three hours enough.

THE GATE

FROM C.2

The finished Rowan brief

A PRD written before the evidence invents its users. You will feel it in the acceptance criteria.

FROM C.1 PACK

The constraints

Two engineers for three weeks. No pricing changes. The cancel path stays reachable in-app.

FROM C.1

The one sentence

Paste it at the top. Everything in the spec either serves it or is a non-goal.

Module 2's PRD started from a prompt. This one starts from evidence.

FOR ROWAN: rule out the CEO's three screens in non-goals, with a reason

THE THREE MOVES · 1 HOUR 30

1 Frame, then draft 40 MIN · FOUR PASSES

Pass 1 is you, alone, ten minutes, no AI: the decision, the one flow, who it is for, what you are deliberately not doing, and the decisions already made that you do not want re-opened. Skipping it is the number one failure mode — hand the model a blank and it returns the industry average.

PASS 2 · THE BRIEF

Role: senior PM writing an internal PRD an engineering team will estimate from on Thursday. **Task:** draft the PRD below. **Context:** [the C.2 brief in full + your pass-1 notes]. **Format:** Problem · Goal with the metric · Non-goals · The one flow, step by step · Acceptance criteria as testable statements · Edge cases · Open questions. **Guardrails:** use only the users and numbers in the brief. Do not invent a persona, a market size or a competitor. Where the brief is silent, put the gap in Open questions. Ask me anything unclear before you start.

PASS 3 · THE THREE THAT PAY

What did you assume that I didn't tell you? · Which acceptance criteria could pass while the user still fails the task? · What edge cases would embarrass us in production?

2 The two sections that score 30 MIN

Non-goals — 4 to 6 lines, each "Not in scope: X. Why: Y." The why is evidence or a constraint, never taste: "Not in scope: recurring meetings. Why: the decision we are settling is about a single booking; recurrence doubles the state model and answers nothing." Without this section, scope is whatever the reader assumes.

Acceptance criteria — testable, or it is an opinion. **Not** "fast and intuitive." **Instead:** "A coordinator who has never seen this screen sends a booking request to 4 people in under 90 seconds, without opening another tab."

PASTE THIS

Rewrite each acceptance criterion so a QA engineer could pass or fail it without asking me a question. **Where a threshold is missing, ask me for the number — do not choose one yourself.**

3 Cut to one flow 20 MIN · CUTTING IS FREE ON PAPER

Two lists. **In:** the single flow that settles your one sentence. **Not now:** everything else, kept in the document under a heading — you are dating your thinking, not deleting it. The test: if this were missing, could a person still attempt the task end to end? If yes, it is Not now.

6 half-working-screens

1 flow that runs

SELF-CHECK · SPEC, 20 PTS

- ☐ A stranger could build the one flow **without calling you**
- ☐ **Non-goals exist**, 4+ lines, each with a reason
- ☐ Every threshold is a number **you** chose, not one it invented
- ☐ Edge cases named: empty, error, overflow, permission, and your domain's own
- ☐ The goal names the metric that would move, and nothing contradicts the C.2 brief

THE CUT · BUILT IN C.4

IN · THE ONE FLOW

NOT NOW · DATED, NOT DELETED

THE FASTEST FAIL

A feature list with no non-goals — the prototype, the estimate and the demo end up being about slightly different products.

STEP 2 · JUDGEMENT LINE

What the AI got wrong here, and what I did about it: